

More Love Poems Innit

A sequence of poems by
Rik Roots

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Dedicated to Nigel
(because 25 years is just the start of it)

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Catch

Shall I make the wave stop mid-tumble, salt
curl on a cusp of froth? Or snare the breeze
in hawthorn buds, freeze street garbage into art,
halt the heron leaping from her nest? Can I catch
your eyes lost in that smile you share with cats?

I want to secure this, and this, in a chest
and store them safe from harm; a charm to keep
the scavenger who leaches chalk from bone
at bay – but I fail. These instances lie: the wave

must crash, the hawthorn bloom; litter must burn
as the heron's neck stretches and her wings
slap rings into water. And bones must bleach –
but not yet, my love, not yet! Not while
the fractions between us keep our eyes wide.

The One

"There are many different ways to be a man,"
she said, *"and ten thousand tricks to falling*
in love." Oh my sweet, I need to count them all,
here, now, and let them cleave this time
to countless, endless moments. What caught me first –
a laugh to etch a web of cracks in diamond?
A glance to snatch my eye wide? A tightened
sinew caught across your neck? A gust
of pit sweat, that snort, your tap of fingers
on my drum-tight chest, a lip mid-bite –
I topple into love with everything
you do, demon infection who strikes and lingers,
who plays my blood like a deep-note cello: smite
me yesterday, tomorrow! You make me sing!

Just Do It

It's like that moment when
someone, burning the map,
shouts: let's follow that starling!
Like when Mum tosses baby
into the air and bellows: catch!
It's as if Charlie, finding gold
in his chocolate, eats the ticket;
or you turn to me with eyes

cool and warm and half-lashed
and say: let's move in together –
and we leap elsewhere, each day
another jump, mapless, flying
free of care or promise of candy,
daring the world to deliver.

Midnap

Be warned, I keep this dreamhouse
sparse – kitchen, bedroom, lounge:
no space for broom or store. We pit
spoor in a yard with face-mixed friends.

To each room, an altar – to hope,
to growth, to you. Aside a bed a steam
of steeped assam, a clip of bleach-frayed
punk spike; across a sofa's curves a match
of lobe-woven lungs, that shared air
a safe dock for fond, blood warm words.

A galley pan upon the flame; a sweat
of nettles in broth, their weal inks drawn
and spiced like us by fresh starts: hug to me
tight, my love, while I wake.

The It of It

A river in flood, fast and deep and yet still – the base
boulders are too low to ripple this quiet sprint of water,
and there's no wind to tessellate its slate-cloud reflections.
Our steps should be smothered by a pitch of roars, but not here:
only the arch of my foot can tag the river's rumble, an ache
at the instep when I unboot and desock and let mud meet skin.

I want you to know this. A camera can catch a mallard arsing
and diving beneath a driven, rooty log but what of the husp
caught in my throat as I watch? What technician's instrument
can hope to trap that moment when the swirl of distant starlings
merge with the first dance of evening midges around my head
and my eyes splice and perspectives collapse and still

the river floods. No words. Instead, a setter at point, keen
to snout deadly waters to fetch the spinning bird, now bearded
in weeds, a braille of droplets running a soon-lost verse
across its wings. No words – until a sketch of fingers tap to
my palm, your hand gathering me back into me: "Only an idiot
walks barefoot here: look at the litter and shit and stuff!"

JoJo

When you glove my hand in yours I hold
breath in my throat, count ruby stars
as they drift within shuttered lids.

A pitch in my ear, a whine; carpet tufts trip
at my toes; a huff of aged bacon; the sweat
of your palms as you pull at my arm.

I spread fingers, take the mewling weight –
soft and hot and bones in fur: so puny,
this kitten, her claws clasped on my thumb.

Open our eyes: the birth of us is done.

As Silk Strokes Amber

If the cholera had achieved its aim to drain the last drops
from Nikola's guts, or that boxcar blast had cooked
Thomas's flesh to char, or Michael had not apprenticed
as a bookbinder or – worse – had let the better bred
beat him back to his trade, then I would have to handwrite

these lines by candle flame. No bulb to glow, nor switch
to spark it alive; no wires or waves to scrunch space
through time and tie lovers together. The ink in my quill
a day's labour, the paper a week's hunger and yet I would pay
again, again to scratch out these Hallmarked words

*you are my purpose,
my pulse, my breath
and my love*

because never can I imagine a life of mine where you are not
the root of it. Here I am, the one who thrives in the midst
of your infection, your flames; a man immune to the sneers
of know-alls, gladly annealed to his fate to stay strangely
entangled in your electro-magnetic, magnificent charm.

Spring Fling

We first furled as brown trees blushed pink
in frosts: him taller, I more muscled,
we made a knit of tongues, a fret of limbs
as we drank ourselves to convulsions.

We were done before the petals fell.
As cherries swelled I listened again
and over to the mix-tape he gave me:
'All that's left is a band of gold ...'

I can't play his music today. As seasons
blew the tech grew and consumed us all;
soon that keen flash of his iceberg eyes
will melt from my wits, like a wish.

This thing we share is not that thing

We were too drunk, that first time, a mix
of wines and beers and petrol-fume tequila
salting our clown attempts to joust meat –
no, this thing we share is not that thing.

We found it later, this thing we share,
in a different dive. It twisted slowly
from our mouths – a fine-wrought choke,
each phrase or joke a link to chain us close.

Don't get me wrong. Our thing is love
as much as tree is wood or mud is dust.
There was no grace in our attempts to find
that thing together: *"my mate fancies you!"*

I still share this thing, though he is gone
from me. See? Here it is! Our secret tongue
of trigger words hoop in my ear each time
I window-shop for never-trade: tasty cock!

Central Station, Islington

His walk is a stammer of toe pokes and heel scuffs –
an eye-stunned debutante at his first gay venue.

A showboat couple performs at the bar, their attempts
to eat the other's face blocking paths to alcohol.

She stands almost demure, her forthright courts black
on her feet; foundation fails to hide white stubbles.

The loud ones hang out at the back, pool cue weapons
slapped over biceps far wider than their twig legs.

Two – no, three – quiet and attentive in their corners.
They pull smoke from sticks in metronome drags.

The sightseers gaggle near the stage, boys in tight jeans
corralled by their keep-the-fuck-away babes.

There's regulars here too: Pert Pete, Oxblood Andy –
Reg the Righteous has made a clean-shirt effort.

As we enter our hands palm, hot in their fingery tangle;
we know the flows of this space: we hunt as a team.

Sirens

*"There is a deep-sea Jesus who once hammered
his hands into coral for the glory of God."*

I nod at his words, wise to his tales.

"Does he eat rafts of sharks for breakfast?"

His smile is a tight line, un-arched,
a clench of flesh in the egg of his head.

*"He has wracks for his hair-locks – he would die
for your sins!"* I kneel already: my elbows

denting his pastel thigh – so soft, this knit
of oil-dark tufts that net my fingers.

"How do you know this," I ask his eyes,
five fathoms above; watch as they close.

Like a spring tide his palms spread
their warm weight over my scalp –

knead and sculpt, push deep my wrasse lips
to consume the treasures that anchor our needs.

Burn

I've been lost in memories so long,
sieving ashes for clinkers.

I wake sick for a dead place, its echo
an ember, brittle yet sharp.

I slept, watched membranes hatch
– plasmas too chill for the touch

and yet I tried to hold each one close
for they were me, once,

before I shattered myself for the gift
of cock love – oh, I have sinned

and still I sin as I yawn and shake the dead
me from my flesh and turn

and lag you tight in my limbs, my lover,
for I must burn!

Prowler

*'Tis all a Chequer-board of Nights and Days
Where Destiny with Men for Pieces plays:
Hither and thither moves, and mates, and slays,
And one by one back in the Closet lays.
~~ Omar Khayyam*

I see you! I have no clue why you stand
more focused in my gaze, one of many
jackboot skins in their identikit threads –
your smile, perhaps? That angle of eyes
to nose to chin just one degree the better?
No time for questions as a tension starts
its slow build through my heels, my hip.

I hunt by instinct: there's a lust in me
that can hammer weeds through concrete,
take a man by a thick of neck and shake
him to a torrent of shivers, pelt slicked
in sweats as a howl rips from his throat ...

I didn't choose this thing; all that I can ever be –
for good or ill, for hate or hope – was sealed
in my cells before my first astonished breath.

I know how this ends, see, the way I tease
you from your mates when the bar shuts,
the lines you feed me as I coax your fool belief
that you are the alpha, I your toy for the time
that remains before the sun erupts. We have
necessities to cull, my unknown friend,
and my hunger burgeons beyond needs.

Well Met

Four moons in the sky tonight: new waxed full
waned – what gift is this? I thought you trouble
when we met, big boots and attitude enough
to tip the world to bruises.

This scratch etches across a serpent's head
inked through skin to the bone within. We lie
in a bed of hawthorns and nettles: you, me,
poisons, provocations.

I like the way you flinch as I push a digit's tip
in traces over your blistered thigh. Your eyes
catch satellites in tear-pools; your fingers net
a skull as we mix lips.

Who are you, bully machine? What brings you
here to me, to my pop-up nest of hurts
and hopes to let my limbs surround your flesh
with sweat and urgent heat?

I strip dock sheets from their stalk, crush them
for juice and balm my wheals – my hedgerow
birthright gives me this know, even here
in your city of dreams.

"What's your name, mate?" My name is silence.
It takes a minute for me to dress and leave
our bower, step goat-sure through derelictions.
Clouds rile the heavens.

Prosopagnosia

On good days all I see are mouths. Some pout,
some chew. A yawning maw is an adventure
with crampons and ropes. Smirks are welcome;
smiles often false. Beards lag the lies within.

Other times are less fortunate: a morning
spent in the company of walking noses can trip
me to madness – how can the shapes of snouts
be so infinite? Such colourful vents to the soul.

One time I walked among flocks of brows perched
on foreheads. Once I skipped through henge-fields
of chins. Sometimes I see only a swirl of palettes
that slowly churn, topped by the occasional hat.

I have no control over what my stuttering mind
will choose to specify. My horror is a surround
of eyes – all stare and know and judge, dismiss ...
except yours, my love. Only yours can I trust.

Nigel

You snatched me back in ninety three,
a crook-toothed smile spun through dim light
to hook my eyes, a scatter of laughs and limbs
lanky in jeans and tee – not my type
at all and yet, and yet

here we are, somehow, boxed together
so hard by that life we built I dare not guess
where you end, I start – a melt of cheese
over toast, cream and crunch, a shrine
to sated lusts and still, and still –

Rain in Venice

We find her hidden from invaders beyond a tight arched alley,
beneath a bridge bricked between tenements. School kid shouts
echo across the cobbled piazza whose puddles complete a mirror.

*"We could borrow her:
you do the sculling
and I'll do the song."*

I can smell linen in the air, and a boil of cabbage and fish.
Our quarry, she lists: her cushions sheen with a first blush
of emerald mold. Still it rains; the veil of drops grows heavy

when we kiss in this tourist-missed pocket, as open to stares
as a Doge slumped in his woodworm throne. *"We can have cake,"*
you hint, *"and prosecco. Happy birthday, my dirty old queer!"*

Garden Party

I spot a crease in the lap
of your shirt, there by the hip;
a moment's stroke teases
the cloth flatter – did you notice
me touch you? Hands at your neck:
I watch as they weave a knot
along the nylon luster
that gathers your throat –

"You look good," I say, no lie
in my words. "You'll out-queen
the Queen herself!" Your shrug
is a novel of nerves and conquests,
your smile a story half-told –
a legend tensed to break bud.

Some days the pride I feel
for you stabs in my lungs
so hard it slaughters words
like caged piglets – do you notice
my joy when we share space,
you and me, the world beyond?
I spot a crumb on your lip,
thumb it away as you tell me
your plot to rule this day.

Safe

You walked in my footsteps, once in time,
on Dymchurch beach; I had mudlark eyes,
could spot the squirt of a razorshell
at ten yards. Safe I steered us then,
gust-bent in our treads over shift-sands
and flotsams as the lugs spouted brine
warnings: quick the tide shifts.

No risk, no gain – do you not understand
that without you I can risk nothing?
Sometimes I hate you for making me live:
welt-heel, mud instep, gash-toe.

Hero

Each evening, when we tell our day over dinner,
you reveal a new bruise – here the weal of a grip
so tight it bracelets your wrist entire; there
a kicked shin, a train-wreck scratch on the arm.
A rose of ovals tacked mid-chest tally a fight
taken to knuckles amid a gale of cuss words.

I love that you smile as you spin your epics
of tiny victories – that bone-and-joints man
who drew strength from your flesh to stand
and walk to his food; the tiny woman adrift
in hostile memories who found your eye
and joined you in song. As we settle and eat

I watch you in glances and know: the well
of care sprung from your core is too deep!
You have no choice but to see each new face
as a friend waiting to hatch, to smithy tears
to jewels and worry smiles from scowls – even
mine – and I adore you for it beyond wounds.

Headbreak

I've never had my heart broken. Never
felt my chest pressed between iron
when someone whispers go away;
get lost. Or that malicious fib: maybe
some time apart will make us stronger –
no. Those are the words that put boots
in my brain, set blood in my face; how
can such small words sideline my thoughts
into an endless loop of why, why, why?

I've lied, too. That lad whose laugh
went from intriguing to embarrassing
in a week; the (many) men whose beauty
grew alongside the level of phenols
chugging my blood – I think I remembered
to thank them; us uglies need to be kind.

You can break my head. Sometimes you
do it daily: selective listening; a thoughtless
word – just as I can tighten your springs
and set you up for argument. We own
each other's remote control and, when bored,
the fun of channel-surfing through emotions
and reactions is too tempting to refuse. Such
is the life we have both embraced, eyes open.

The Last Breath is the First Breath

It's been a heavy year, my love,
like weights around a diver's chill waist
dragging our faces through brine

and yet here we are, separated
as fireworks fizz and bust between us
your voice in my ear at midnight –

Happy New Year!

Happy! Happy!

Love You!

– and then you're gone, dead line
as the frail patients on your night-watch list
seek comfort from deep memories

and I on my knees at prayer
to a shattered night sky: give us strength
to draw joy from each other

and calm when I hear your key unlock
our shared door as I wake and welcome you
like bubbles in dance under waves.